

Poetry





About the Course

Students learn to love the sight and sound of words and appreciate history through daily poetry reading covering a wide variety of authors and poems from the 19th century.



Placement & Combining Tips

Students in Grades 5-8 can easily be combined for these lessons as all grades use nearly the same texts this year, although older grades read additional selections and have corresponding composition assignments.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
5-6	Poetry: Grades 5-6 5 times/week 5 min	Jump Back, Paul: The Life and Poems of Paul Laurence Dunbar Over the River and Through the Wood: An Anthology of Nineteenth-Century American Children's Poetry The Poet: Pauline Johnson The Crescent Moon

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Poetry: Grades 5-6				
Poetry: Grades 5-6	Poetry: Grades 5-6	Poetry: Grades 5-6	Poetry: Grades 5-6	Poetry: Grades 5-6



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

Poetry: Grades 5-6



Jump Back, Paul: The Life and Poems of Paul Laurence Dunbar



Over the River and Through the Wood: An Anthology of Nineteenth-Century American Children's Poetry



The Poet: Pauline Johnson



The Crescent Moon



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)
(No Subject Supplies Assigned)



Quick Links

Poetry: Grades 5-6

∞ [Over the River Public Domain Poetry List](#)

Click THIS text
or scan the QR
code for links.



Poetry: Grades 5-6

How To Teach



Introduce

Tell something about the poet or the kind of poem or fable to prepare students. Remember that poems are like paintings—they not only convey ideas, they create an experience with the sound of words, the way the words are arranged, and the emotions, thoughts, and images they evoke.



Read

Read the poem aloud in order to hear the sounds and meter. Have students read it aloud as well as it is helpful to hear poetry read by different voices. Try to read paying attention to the punctuation as well as the line breaks to get the sense of the poem.



Discuss

Allow students to share any thoughts or connections. What are your impressions of the poem? Talk about anything that stood out to you: the images, ideas, words, phrases, sounds, or even physical look of the poem. What kinds of things is the poem about?



Reread

Read (or have the student read) the poem again.



Connect

Students may choose to add poems to their Commonplace Book or mark them to copy later.

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 1

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ NOTE

You will usually spend one week reading the poems from ~5 pages (depending on the size of the illustrations and length of poems). You can pick 1-3 to read each day and reread them as much as you like. Poetry is made to be read many times. Lessons give some ideas for discussing a particular poem, but those are only suggestions. You'll also focus particularly on getting to know the poets Rabindranath Tagore in Term 1, Pauline Johnson in Term 2, and Paul Laurence Dunbar in Term 3. Feel free to use the index of the book to look up other poems by poets you particularly like.

→ INTRO

Almost all the poems we'll read this year were written from 1800-1900 AD (the time period you'll learn about in many of your other lessons as well). So, as you read, imagine children like you listening to these same poems about 200 years ago! First, let's start by reading a poem that reminds us to enjoy (and not overthink) the poems we'll read this year.

∞ Link: Introduction To Poetry

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.31-36 Chapter: Growing Things
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

★ TEACHER NOTE

Optional: Read the Introduction and share information with students throughout the year.

Note: The "Holidays" chapter of Over the River and Through the Wood is not scheduled until Term 3. Feel free to also read from that chapter during Thanksgiving, Christmas, New Year's, etc.

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 2

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Our poem today is by Paul Laurence Dunbar. He was one of the first Black Americans to earn a living as a writer, and he inspired many other writers after him. He also became friends with Orville Wright and his brother Wilbur (who you may remember as the inventors of the airplane)! The Wright brothers owned a printing press and published Dunbar's first writings.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.36 "The Seedling" by Paul Laurence Dunbar

- Do you notice how the seedling starts talking in the poem? Have you ever heard a seedling talk? Of course not! Poets sometimes imagine that things like plants or animals can talk to help us think about them in new ways. The fancy word for this is "personification." Do you notice any other examples of the seed doing things only people normally do?

→ NOTE

You'll read an interesting biography about Paul Laurence Dunbar in Term 3 that includes several more of his poems.

★ TEACHER NOTE

∞ **Article Link:** How To Read a Poem Out Loud

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 3

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.31 "Tree Feelings" by Charlotte Perkins Gilman

- How does the poet use personification in this poem? What human traits does the poet give the trees?

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

p.31-36 Chapter: Growing Things
Use any additional time to pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 4

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.31-36 Chapter: Growing Things
Pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

★ TEACHER NOTE

Alternatively, explore more poems on p.37-44 and 51-54 of this chapter, as we will not have time to cover those sections in lessons. You can also use the author index on page 559 to find other poems by Paul Laurence Dunbar.

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 5

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ INTRO

Rabindranath Tagore was born in 1861 in Calcutta, India, and grew up in a family that loved art, music, and ideas. He was a poet, short-story writer, composer, playwright, and painter who spent his life creating in many different ways. In 1913, he became the first non-European writer to be awarded the Nobel Prize for Literature. He also composed the national anthems for both India and Bangladesh, making his words a lasting part of two nations. Once a week this term, we'll read poems by Rabindranath Tagore, exploring themes like mothers, children, and nature.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.8 "On the Seashore"

- What are the children doing at the seashore?
- What might the "seashore of endless worlds" symbolize?

p.6-10
Pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 6

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Our poet today is Ina Coolbrith. She was born Josephine Smith. Her uncle Joseph Smith was the founder of the Mormon church, and her father (who died when she was just a few months old) was a church leader, though she concealed this most of her life. Her ties to the church were severed in childhood when her mother remarried a non-Mormon, and they moved to California to follow the gold rush. She published her first poems as a teenager and worked for over two decades as a librarian, encouraging the writing careers of others. She became California's first Poet Laureate in 1915.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.50 "In Blossom Time" by Ina Coolbrith

- "In Blossom Time" is written in quatrain, meaning each verse contains exactly four lines. Sometimes a whole poem is written in quatrain, as in this poem, and sometimes just part of the poem uses this structure. Quatrains usually have a specific rhyme structure. In this poem, the structure is ABCB, meaning that the words ending the second and fourth lines rhyme (B), but the first (A) and third (C) lines do not. Quatrains can have other rhyme structures, such as AABB or ABBA.

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Ina Coolbrith Bio

Poetry: Grades 5-6

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Term 1

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 7

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Last lesson, we learned that a quatrain is when each verse in a poem has exactly four lines. We'll read two more poems that use this format today, but have different rhyme structures.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.44 "Prairie Fires" by Eudora May Stone

- What is the rhyme scheme of "Prairie Fires"?

p.46 "The Mushroom's Soliloquy" by Hannah Flagg Gould

- What is the rhyme scheme of "The Mushroom's Soliloquy"? Note that a soliloquy is when a character speaks their private thoughts or feelings out loud without anyone else around to hear them. What are some of the mushroom's thoughts?

★ TEACHER NOTE

"Prairie Fires" has an ABAB rhyme scheme.

"The Mushroom's Soliloquy" has an AABB rhyme scheme.

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 8

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.45 "The Johnny Cake" Author Unknown

- "The Johnny Cake" has three lines per stanza, which is called a tercet. The pace of a tercet is often slower than a couplet or quatrain. What is the rhyme scheme?

p.44 "To Make A Prairie" by Emily Dickinson

- Notice "To Make A Prairie" is both very brief and uses an unconventional AAABB rhyme structure. Why might Dickinson have chosen this for her subject? Note that reverie means to daydream or be lost in imagination.

★ TEACHER NOTE

"The Johnny Cake" rhyme scheme is ABB.

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 9

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.44-50 Chapter: Growing Things

Pick and choose poems from these pages.

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 10

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.12-13 "Sleep-Stealer"

- Do you think someone really stole the baby's sleep?
- What phrase is repeated throughout the poem? Why do you think this is?
- How does the poem blur the line between the real world and the imaginative world?

Poetry: Grades 5-6

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Term 1

p.11-15

If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 11

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.58 "Give Me The Splendid Silent Sun" by Walt Whitman
(We'll learn more about Walt Whitman later in the year.)

- What examples of alliteration (repeated sounds) and/or repetition (repeated words) can you find in this poem?
- The poem in our book leaves out some lines. The verse ends like this:

These demanding to have them, (tired with ceaseless excitement,
and rack'd by the war-strife,)
These to procure incessantly asking, rising in cries from my heart,
While yet incessantly asking still I adhere to my city,
Day upon day and year upon year O city, walking your streets,
Where you hold me enchain'd a certain time refusing to give me
up,
Yet giving to make me gluttoned, enrich'd of soul, you give me
forever faces;
(O I see what I sought to escape, confronting, reversing my cries,
I see my own soul trampling down what it ask'd for.)

- This poem was written during the Civil War. In fact, Whitman volunteered as a nurse caring for wounded soldiers, and the experience inspired some of his most powerful poems. Knowing this, how does the line about being "rack'd by the war-strife" impact Whitman's longing for peaceful nature?

★ TEACHER NOTE

The full poem is split into two distinct parts — the first longing for nature and solitude, the second embracing the city. However, the second part does include content that may not be suitable for your students, so it is not included in the book or the lesson. Be sure to preview if you wish to share with your students.

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 12

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.59 "A Day" Emily Dickinson

- We previously read Emily Dickinson's "To Make A Prairie" (p. 44), which used an unconventional rhyme structure. "A Day" includes a more traditional quatrain (four-line verse) and rhyme structure. Can you identify what that rhyme structure is?

★ TEACHER NOTE

"A Day" rhyme scheme is ABCB.

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 13

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.57-62 Chapter: Landscapes and Seasons
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

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WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 14

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.57-62 Chapter: Landscapes and Seasons

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 15

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.19 "Playthings"

- How does the poem compare child's play to adult work, and which seems more satisfying?
- What "art" has the adult forgotten?
- What does the poem mean when it says adults spend their lives seeking "costly playthings"? Does this create success and happiness?

p.16-19

If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 4 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 16

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

John Greenleaf Whittier is known as a passionate abolitionist opposing slavery long before the Civil War, a prolific writer, and a friend to several other famous writers. During his lifetime, he became one of America's most popular poets. He also ran for Congress twice and remained involved in politics throughout his life. He spent his later years writing about religion, nature, and country life. He moved in a remarkable circle of friends that included abolitionist Frederick Douglass, poets Ralph Waldo Emerson and Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, and novelist Mark Twain.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.73 "The Barefoot Boy" by John Greenleaf Whittier

- This poem uses a metaphor, which is a comparison of two things that are generally unlike. In this case, a boy is compared with a prince. Common metaphors include phrases like "time is money." Metaphors are sometimes confused with similes, which also compare two things but contain the words "like" or "as," such as "life is like a roller coaster." What are some more examples of metaphors and/or similes?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: John Greenleaf Whittier Bio

WEEK 4 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 17

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.70-76 Chapter: Landscapes and Seasons

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

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- As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 4 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 18

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.70-76 Chapter: Landscapes and Seasons
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

→ WRITE

(Optional) Use today and tomorrow to write a poem about the current month or season.

WEEK 4 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 19

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.70-76 Chapter: Landscapes and Seasons
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

→ WRITE

(Optional) Continue writing or revising a poem about the month or season you're currently experiencing!

WEEK 4 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 20

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.23-24 "Fairyland"

- Why do you think the child whispers the secret to the mother instead of telling everyone?
- In what ways can imagination transform ordinary places into something wondrous and special?

→ VIEW

∞ Image Link: Tulsi Plant

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.20-24
If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 21

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

You may already recognize Louisa May Alcott as the author of Little Women, but she is also recognized as a poet. Growing up in Concord, Massachusetts, her family was neighbors and friends with writers and poets Ralph Waldo Emerson, Henry David Thoreau, and Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, all of whom influenced her love of writing from an early age. She wrote novels, short stories, and poetry that often drew on her own life and the social causes she cared about, including abolition and women's rights. Her poetry also often reflected the Transcendentalist

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Louisa May Alcott Bio

★ TEACHER NOTE

This poem uses an ABCB rhyme scheme in the first 8 lines, but then changes to an AABCCB scheme in the refrain (the last 6 lines). This creates a "bouncing" effect much like bees bouncing from flower to flower. The poem

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love of nature, finding meaning and beauty in the natural world.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.83 "Morning Song of the Bees" by Louisa May Alcott

- Look for rhymes and mark which words rhyme. Can you find a pattern?

almost sounds like a song or hymn when read aloud.

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 22

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.79 "The Lady-Bug And the Ant" by Lydia Sigourney

- The Ant notices the Lady-Bug's mockery but simply keeps walking "at the same industrious pace." What does this tell us about the Ant's character? Why might the poet have chosen not to have the Ant respond with words?
- What is the lesson the Lady-Bug learns? The poem ends without telling us what happens to the Lady-Bug when winter arrives. Why do you think the poet left this part out?
- This poem was written for children in 1836. Do you think its message still applies today? Can you think of modern examples that reflect the same ideas?

★ TEACHER NOTE

To keep to the lesson time, you may want to choose just one discussion question you think students will enjoy most and save the others for the next lesson (if students are really interested).

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 23

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.82-85 Chapter: Creepie Crawlies
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 24

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.82-85 Chapter: Creepie Crawlies
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 25

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.28-29 "Paper Boats"

- What is inside the boat during the poem?
- What do you think the child imagines will happen to the paper boats on their journey?
- Why do you think the child hopes that "someone in some strange land" will find the boats?

→ VIEW

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∞ Image Link: Shiuli Flower (The English name is night-blooming jasmine.)

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.25-29

If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 26

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Helen Hunt Jackson experienced many hardships in her life. She turned to writing to help her through her grief and went on to publish poetry, children's books, and travel writing. She also happened to grow up as a close friend of poet Emily Dickinson! Later in life, Jackson became a fierce champion for Native American rights, writing a book called *A Century of Dishonor* (1881) after hearing a moving speech by Chief Standing Bear, and then a novel called *Ramona* (1884) that told the story of California's displaced Mission Indians.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.103 "The Shining Little House" by Helen Hunt Jackson

- How many lines are in each stanza (verse) of the poem? Can you identify the rhyme structure?
- What rhymes do you see? Is there a pattern?
- What do you think the lesson of this poem is? Do you agree?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Helen Hunt Jackson Bio

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 27

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.101 "Robert of Lincoln" by William Cullen Bryant

- Bryant uses a classic poetic device called onomatopoeia at the end of each stanza. Onomatopoeia is when a word phonetically imitates the sound it describes, such as buzz, hiss, bang, or sizzle. Can you think of some other onomatopoeic words?

p.101-104 Chapter: Feathered Friends

If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

★ TEACHER NOTES

∞ Video Link: How to Pronounce Onomatopoeia

The next lesson includes "The Raven" by Edgar Allan Poe. Preview to see if the poem is too intense for your students.

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 28

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ NOTE

This lesson includes "The Raven" by Edgar Allan Poe. Preview to see if the poem is too intense for your students.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.105-107 "The Raven" by Edgar Allan Poe

- "The Raven" has a very strong, almost musical beat that you can feel when you read it aloud. How does that steady, pounding rhythm affect the mood of the poem?
- Poe uses a lot of rhyme and repetition, especially at the end of each stanza. How does hearing the same word over and over change the way it feels by the end of the poem, compared to the first time it appears?
- Can you find examples of onomatopoeia in "The Raven"?

★ TEACHER NOTES

One example of onomatopoeia is "the silken sad uncertain rustling."

To keep to the lesson time, you may want to choose just one discussion question you think students will enjoy most and save the others for the next lesson (if students are really interested).

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Term 1

OR

p.101-104 Chapter: Feathered Friends
Pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 29

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.101-104 Chapter: Feathered Friends
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 30

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.33-34 "The Merchant"

- What gifts would you bring home if you traveled to magical lands like the child in the poem?
- What do the different gifts chosen for the mother, father, and brother reveal about how the child sees each person?

p.30-34
If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 31

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Emily Dickinson spent almost her whole life in Amherst, Massachusetts, rarely leaving her family home. She was a serious gardener who grew all kinds of flowers and plants, and you can see her love of nature throughout her poems, which are full of flowers, bees, and changing seasons that she observed right in her own backyard. Even though she only published a small handful of poems while she was alive, she secretly wrote nearly 1,800 of them, and most weren't discovered until after she died in 1886. Today, she's considered one of the greatest American poets. Imagine her going back and forth between her garden and her writing desk, getting inspired by everything she saw growing around her.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.125 "In the Garden" by Emily Dickinson

- The poem is titled "In the Garden," yet the garden itself is never really described. Why might Dickinson have chosen that title?
- In the third stanza, Dickinson uses an em dash—some consider this her signature style! The dashes in her poems create pauses and make the reader slow down. These em dashes are often left out of her poems when they are reprinted. (Unfortunately, they were left out of many of her poems in this book.) Note that many people today consider the use of em dashes a sign that something was written by AI (such as ChatGPT)!

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Emily Dickinson Bio

★ TEACHER NOTE

You can find the original versions of Dickinson's poems online to see where the em dashes were placed.

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[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 32

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.123 "Humming-Bird Song" by Frank Dempster Sherman

- Notice how the short, fast lines sound similar to how a hummingbird quickly darts around when read aloud!

As time allows, explore p.122-126 Chapter: Feathered Friends.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 33

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.122-126 Chapter: Feathered Friends

Pick and choose poems from these pages.

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 34

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.122-126 Chapter: Feathered Friends

Pick and choose poems from these pages.

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

OR

Use the author index in the back of the book to explore other poems by Emily Dickinson, or explore poems on pages 105-121 that weren't included in lessons.

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 35

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.36 "Vocation"

- Why does the child think the hawker, gardener, and watchman have exciting lives?
- How does the poem contrast school life with the child's longing for independence?
- What does the poem suggest about our tendency to imagine that other lives are freer or happier than our own?

p.35-39

If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 8 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 36

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

American poet Laura E. Richards had pretty impressive parents! Her mother was Julia Ward Howe, who wrote "Battle Hymn of the Republic," and her father ran the Perkins Institution for the Blind. She followed in her family's accomplished footsteps by writing nearly a hundred books, becoming a pioneer of nonsense poetry for kids, and one of her stories was even turned into a movie. She and her sister won the Pulitzer Prize for Biography for a book they wrote about their famous mother, making them the first women ever to win that award.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.134 "The Sad Story of the Dandy Cat" by Laura E. Richards

- A dandy is a man who cares too much about appearances and fashion.
- Using an animal to comment on human behavior is called allegory. Can you think of other stories where an animal is used to comment on human behavior? What makes using an animal an effective way to deliver that kind of message to a reader?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Laura E. Richards Bio

★ TEACHER NOTE

Other examples of allegory would be any of Aesop's Fables and the book Charlotte's Web.

WEEK 8 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 37

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.132 "The Three Little Kittens" by Eliza Lee Cabot Follen

- This poem originated from an old British nursery rhyme, though it's usually attributed to American Eliza Lee Cabot Follen. The earliest known published version was in 1817, while Follen's version was published later in 1841.
- Like "The Sad Story of the Dandy Cat," this poem also uses allegory to deliver a moral or lesson. What is the lesson (or lessons) being taught here?

WEEK 8 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 38

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.129-132 Chapter: Domestic Animals
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

→ WRITE

(Optional) Write a poem about a pet you have (or would like to have).

WEEK 8 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 39

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.134-138 Chapter: Domestic Animals
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

→ WRITE

(Optional) Continue writing or revising your poem about a pet you have (or would like to have).

Poetry: Grades 5-6

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Term 1

WEEK 8 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 40

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.40 "Authorship"

- Did you catch the line about the child making a paper boat? Do you think this is the same child who made paper boats in a previous poem?
- What kinds of stories does the child wish the father would write?
- How does the poem show the difference between the way children and adults value work, play, and creativity?

p.40-45

If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 9 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 41

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Ella Wheeler Wilcox grew up on a farm in Wisconsin, started writing poetry around age eight, and was widely published in magazines by the time she was a teen! She became one of the most widely read American poets of her era. She wrote nearly 40 books of poetry and prose, including the famous lines "Laugh, and the world laughs with you; weep, and you weep alone," which she wrote after comforting a grieving widow on a train. She was also a passionate advocate for animal rights, and this topic came up in several of her poems, like "The Hen's Complaint."

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.145-146 "The Hen's Complaint" by Ella Wheeler Wilcox

- "The Hen's Complaint" uses rhyming couplets. This is when two lines rhyme, usually have the same number of syllables, and usually form a complete sentence or thought. It creates a very "sing-song" cadence that you'll find used everywhere from Dr. Seuss to Shakespeare! We'll learn more about these in a later lesson.

WEEK 9 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 42

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.143 "The Motherless Turkeys" by Marian Douglass

- How would you describe the character of the duck? Goose? Dorking? Hen with one chicken?
- Do you remember what allegory is? This poem also uses allegory to deliver a moral or a lesson. What is the lesson (or lessons) being taught here?

• DEFINITION

A dorking is an English breed of chicken.

WEEK 9 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 43

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.141-142 "Mary's Lamb" Parodies
(You'll find the original poem at the top of the page and the parodies after.)

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

→ WRITE

(Optional) Write your own parody of a common poem or rhyme.

WEEK 9 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 44

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.141-149 Chapter: Domestic Animals

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 9 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 45

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.49 "The Banyan Tree"

The Banyan tree is the national tree of India.

- Why do you think the child wants to be the wind, a bird, or a duck?
- How does the poem show movement through the images?
- What might the child learn from quietly watching nature every day?

→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: Parable of the Banyan Tree

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.46-49

If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 46

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Ralph Waldo Emerson was a Boston-born writer, poet, and philosopher who became one of the most influential thinkers in American history. He was unusually curious about Eastern cultures for his time, and he wove ideas from Hindu, Persian, and Chinese texts into his writing. He had some of the cultural blind spots common to people of his era, but he genuinely broadened the horizons of American readers by introducing them to ideas and traditions from around the world.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.155 "Fable" by Ralph Waldo Emerson

- An allegory typically has two levels of understanding: the literal (the quarrel between the mountain and the squirrel) and the symbolic (what deeper story or moral is being told). What do you think might be the deeper story or moral in this poem?

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 47

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

This poem has an interesting premise. Read the explanation before the

Poetry: Grades 5-6

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poem (in italics) and then read the poem.
p.154 "Billy Rabbit to Mary" by Eliza Lee Cabot Follen

→ WRITE

(Optional) Write your own "response poem" from an animal to a human. Perhaps it's from a cat, who had to be given a bath, or a dog who did something his owners weren't happy about.

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 48

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.153-157 Chapter: Wild Animals
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 49

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.153-157 Chapter: Wild Animals
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 50

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.54 "The Last Bargain"

- Why do you think the child chooses the child instead of the king, the old man, or the fair maiden?
- What do you think the speaker discovers about freedom by the end of the poem?

p.50-54
If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 11 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 51

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.161-163 "The War of the Rats and Mice (Almost A Fairy Tale)" by George W. Ranck

- Why do you think the poet named this "almost a fairy tale"?
- Epic ancient poems like The Iliad tell stories of great warriors and heroes fighting for honor and glory. Ranck uses that same structure but fills it with rats and mice instead of legendary heroes. What makes this contrast humorous? What might Ranck be suggesting about the nature of war and the reasons creatures fight?

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WEEK 11 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 52

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: What Are Rhyming Couplets?

- (Optional) Using "The War of the Rats and Mice (Almost A Fairy Tale)" on pages 161-163, try the exercise in the video where one student (or group of students or teacher) reads the end word of a line and another student (or group of students) reads the end word of the next line.

WEEK 11 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 53

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.161-165 Chapter: Wild Animals

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- Several poems this term were by "anonymous" or "author unknown."
Why might some poets have chosen to publish poems anonymously in the 1800s?

→ CATCH UP

Use any extra time to catch up on any lessons or reread favorite poems from this term.

WEEK 11 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 54

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.161-165 Chapter: Wild Animals

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

→ CATCH UP

Use any extra time to catch up on any lessons or reread favorite poems from this term.

WEEK 11 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 55

□ Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

Revisit favorite poems from Crescent Moon or use this time to catch up on previous lessons.

WEEK 12 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 56

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

There are no exams for this course.

WEEK 12 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 57

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

There are no exams for this course.

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Term 1

WEEK 12 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 58 Exam Week → EXAMS There are no exams for this course.	
WEEK 12 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 59 Exam Week → EXAMS There are no exams for this course.	
WEEK 12 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 60 Exam Week → EXAMS There are no exams for this course.	

Poetry: Grades 5-6

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Term 2

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 61

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Eugene Field was an American poet, journalist, and humorist who built a remarkable career working his way through newspapers across the Midwest, eventually becoming one of the most widely read columnists in the United States. Known as "The Children's Poet," he wrote more than a dozen volumes of poetry and created some of the most beloved children's poems in American literature. His writing was deeply personal, drawing on memories of his New England childhood, his marriage, and the joys of raising a large family. He claimed to be terrible with money and had all his earnings sent directly to his wife to manage.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.181 "The Duel" by Eugene Field

- This poem has an unreliable narrator. This means that the person telling the story can't be trusted. In this case, the poet tells you at the end of each stanza that he got his information from a Chinese plate and an old Dutch clock! He also keeps reminding you not to doubt him (which has the opposite effect), and the improbable ending is delivered with total confidence and zero evidence! It's almost as if the poet is winking at us and letting us in on the joke.
- If time allows, read the poem a second time, looking for these signs (and more) of an unreliable narrator.

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 62

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.182 "The Song of the Roller Skates" by A. C.

- Look for some of the poetic devices we discussed last term, like repetition, onomatopoeia, rhyme structure, etc.
- Have you been to a roller skating rink? Why do you think the poem is divided into two parts (the start and the turn)?
- Read the poem again out loud and see if you feel like you are skating as you read.

★ TEACHER NOTE

Reminder: onomatopoeia is when a word sounds like what it means. Swoop, whiz, and whirl would be examples.

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 63

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.177-184 Chapter: Toys and Play

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- As time allows, use the author index in the back of the book to explore other poems by Eugene Field.

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 64

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Emily Pauline Johnson was born to a Mohawk chief and an English mother, growing up on the Six Nations Reserve in Ontario. She was educated at home, where she was immersed in both English literary traditions and Mohawk oral storytelling and developed a love for poetry. At a time when

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[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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Indigenous peoples regularly faced discrimination, she was raised to value her dual heritage. She turned to writing and performing after her father's death to help support her family, traveling across Canada for 17 years. The first half of each of her shows was performed in Indigenous dress and the second half in an English gown, embodying the two cultures that made her who she was. She published her work under both "E. Pauline Johnson" and her Mohawk name, "Tekahionwake."

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.57 "The Song My Paddle Sings" by E. Pauline Johnson (Tekahionwake; Mohawk)

- What do you remember about personification? Can you find examples of personification in this poem?
- Notice how the poem also includes whole words that are repeated like "blow, blow" and "sleep, sleep." These repetitions help us feel the rhythm of a paddle dipping into the water time and time again.

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 65

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ INTRO

We met Pauline Johnson and learned a little about her in the last lesson. Today, we'll start reading a few pages from a biography about her. We will continue to read her poems and her biography throughout the term.

→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: Pauline Johnson Bio Video (as time allows)

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.1-4

★ TEACHER NOTE

Use this biography if you are not using the book, *The Poet: Pauline Johnson*. You will need to substitute some of the reading from the book with additional poems.

∞ **Article Link:** Pauline Johnson Bio

Besides the poems in *Over the River and Through the Wood*, you can find more of Johnson's poems here. (Scroll down to see linked poems. Teachers should preview poems first.)

∞ **Link:** Pauline Johnson Poems

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 66

Materials: *Over the River and Through the Wood*

→ INTRO

Henry Wadsworth Longfellow was born in Portland, Maine, in 1807 and published his first poem at just 13 years old. After college, he became a professor at Harvard and could speak eight languages, which helped make his poetry rich with ideas and stories from around the world. He became the most popular American poet of his time, writing famous works like "Paul Revere's Ride" and "The Song of Hiawatha." Some of his phrases (like "ships that pass in the night") became so well known that people still use them today without even knowing Longfellow wrote them. He faced heartbreak in his life, including the loss of two wives, but he kept writing through it all and remained one of the most loved poets in the world until his death in 1882.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.185 "The Castle-Builder" by Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

- Henry Wadsworth Longfellow dedicated the poem "The Castle-Builder" in 1848 to his son Erny Longfellow. There were six children in the family (five who lived to adulthood). Charley and Erny were Longfellow's two oldest children. In a journal entry from 1848, Fanny Longfellow (Henry's wife) wrote, "Erny promises to be the poet, Charley the man of action."

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ **Article Link:** Henry Wadsworth Longfellow Bio

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Erny grew up to be a painter. Charley ran away to be a soldier in the Civil War and later became a world traveler.

- In what ways does the poem show a boy growing into a man?

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 67

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.185-189 Chapter: Toys and Play

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- As time allows, use the author index in the back of the book to explore other poems by poets we have been introduced to this year.

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 68

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.185-189 Chapter: Toys and Play

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- As time allows, use the author index in the back of the book to explore other poems by poets we have been introduced to this year.

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 69

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Words which repeat the same sounds (called alliteration) help create rhythm in poetry and writing (and marketing!). Alliteration is the repetition of consonant sounds, particularly at the beginnings of words.

While it is common in poetry, you can find alliteration everywhere.

Examples include brand names like Coca-Cola and Dunkin' Donuts, as well as popular phrases such as "tried and true" and "good as gold." Listen for the alliteration in today's poem by Pauline Johnson.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.57 "The Song My Paddle Sings" by E. Pauline Johnson (Tekahionwake; Mohawk)

Read this poem again today and listen for the alliteration.

- What examples of alliteration did you find in this poem? Can you think of other brands or phrases that use alliteration? Once you start looking, you'll likely see it everywhere! Finally, notice how the repetition in this poem of words like "blow, blow" and "sleep, sleep" mimics the paddling of a canoe.

→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: Good as Gold and Other Alliterations (as time allows)
(The video matches the text, so you can either watch or read.)

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 70

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.5-7

• EXTRA HELPINGS

∞ Article Link: William Wilfred Campbell Bio

∞ Article Link: William Douw Lighthall Bio

∞ Article Link: Duncan Campbell Scott Bio

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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- The three men in the audience were all considered Canada's "Confederation Poets." These poets wrote in the same time period about similar themes, including Canada's natural beauty. Pauline Johnson is sometimes considered to be part of this group of poets. See Extra Helpings if you wish to explore more about them and their poetry.

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 71

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Carolyn Wells was an American writer who got her start working as a librarian before going on to write more than 170 books, including mystery novels, poetry, humor, and children's literature. She's best known for her long-running Fleming Stone detective series, which ran for 61 novels and helped pave the way for the Golden Age of mystery fiction. She was a passionate book collector who amassed an impressive collection of Walt Whitman works, which she donated to the Library of Congress when she passed away.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.208 "Limericks from St. Nicholas" by Carolyn Wells

- Limericks prove that poetry can be playful. Originating in the pubs of England (though named after the Irish city and county of Limerick), they also became popular in children's literature through the 1800s. They are composed of four or five lines with a bouncy AABBA rhyme pattern. Listen for the "bounce" as you read more limericks.

p.207-209

Read other limericks as time allows.

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Carolyn Wells Bio

★ TEACHER NOTE

St. Nicholas magazine was a popular children's magazine founded in 1873 and published until 1940, which contained stories, poems, and puzzles. Many famous writers were first published in its pages.

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 72

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.207-212 Chapter: Nonsense

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

→ WRITE

Try writing your own limerick. Most limericks start with "There once was" or "There was," and it's perfectly fine if they are a bit nonsensical!

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 73

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.207-212 Chapter: Nonsense

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 74

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

The poem "The Song My Paddle Sings" used repetition and rhythm to mimic paddling. Today we'll read another of Johnson's poems about a dogsled. As you read the poem, look for repetition and listen to the rhythm. Can you hear the movement of the dogsled?

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.149 "The Train Dogs" by Pauline Johnson

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 75

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.8-9

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Video Link: Pauline Johnson Archives

WEEK 4 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 76

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Henry David Thoreau was a poet, nature lover, and philosopher from Concord, Massachusetts. He spent his life finding beauty in the natural world and turning it into poetry and essays. Mentored by his friend and neighbor Ralph Waldo Emerson (who we read about in Term 1), he wrote over 20 volumes of poetry, journals, and essays. His poetry paints detailed, beautiful pictures of the woods, seasons, and wildlife he observed on his daily walks. His works have stayed popular for over 150 years.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.253-254 "Prayer" by Henry David Thoreau

- Note that "pelf" is an old word for money or wealth. It's usually used in a negative way. It shares its etymology with the word "pilfer."
- Thoreau is asking for help from God to meet his own high standards for himself. Why do you think he wants to "greatly disappoint my friends"?

WEEK 4 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 77

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Three poets we've discussed in previous weeks make an appearance again this week: Emerson, Longfellow, and Wilcox. What do you remember about Emerson?

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.253 "Forbearance" and "So Nigh Is Grandeur" by Ralph Waldo Emerson

- Use the author index in the back to find more poems by Ralph Waldo Emerson as time allows.

WEEK 4 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 78

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.254-255 "The Barbarous Chief" by Ella Wheeler Wilcox

p.256 "The Village Blacksmith" by Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

- Do you remember either of these poets from Term 1? Feel free to use the author index in the back to explore more of their poems if time allows.

Poetry: Grades 5-6

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WEEK 4 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 79

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.149 Reread "The Train Dogs" by Pauline Johnson.

→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: Preserving Our Culture Dog Sledding – A Métis Tradition

★ TEACHER NOTE

The video contains one instance of mild language at approximately 1:23. You may wish to preview or skip this portion of the video.

WEEK 4 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 80

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.10-11

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

Link: A Cry From An Indian Wife Poem

★ TEACHER NOTE

Sensitive Content Consideration: Illustrations of poems in the book show dead Indigenous warriors.

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 81

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Walt Whitman grew up in Brooklyn, New York, left school at 11 to go to work, and went on to become one of the most important poets in American history. He self-published his famous poetry collection *Leaves of Grass* in 1855, which broke all the rules with its bold, free-flowing style, and he kept revising it for the rest of his life. During the Civil War, he volunteered as a nurse caring for wounded soldiers, and the experience inspired some of his most powerful poems. His influence has never faded, and his idea that poetry should sound like real people talking about real life continues to shape American writing to this day.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.258 "The Commonplace"

- Notice the free verse structure Whitman is known for. There is no strict meter or rhyme scheme. Whitman mimics natural, spoken American speech, using repetition and long lists to build cadence.

→ VIEW

∞ Article Link: 19th Century Commonplace Books of Poetry

→ READ & DISCUSS (OPTIONAL)

p.58 "Give Me The Splendid Silent Sun" by Walt Whitman

If time allows, revisit this Walt Whitman poem from earlier in the year.

★ TEACHER NOTE

"The Commonplace" highlights Whitman's philosophy that ordinary life holds the highest value.

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 82

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

This poem was written "For Irish Children in Exile." Between 1845 and 1855, over 1.5 million adults and children immigrated from Ireland to America due to famine. The poem was a way to help them learn about (or remember) their homeland. It can be fun to read while trying to find some of the many places named on a map, if time allows.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.268 "The Geography of Ireland" by M.A., Sisters of Mercy

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

If you have time, find some of the places mentioned in the poem.
∞ Map Link: Map of Ireland

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 83

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.270-274 Chapter: Learning Lessons
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 84

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.63 "Lady Icicle" by Pauline Johnson

- Read the poem out loud and listen for the repetition and rhythm.
- This poem uses personification. How does Johnson describe Little Lady Icicle?

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 85

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.12-14

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

This poem was based on the Battle of Cut Knife Hill. Watch the video to learn more about and see a reenactment of this battle.
∞ Video Link: Battle of Cut Knife Hill

★ TEACHER NOTE

Sensitive Content Consideration: Illustrations of poems show dead Indigenous warriors.

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 86

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

You might not know her name, but you definitely know her work. Sarah Josepha Hale wrote "Mary Had a Little Lamb" and is also the woman most responsible for making Thanksgiving a national holiday! Born in New Hampshire in 1788, she turned to writing after her husband died young, leaving her with five children to support. She went on to publish poetry, novels, and essays throughout her life. She became the first female editor of an American magazine, using her platform to champion women's education and employment at a time when very few women had access to either. She spent 17 years writing letters to five different presidents lobbying for a national Thanksgiving holiday, and finally succeeded in 1863 when President Lincoln made it official!

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.280 "Birds" by Sarah Josepha Hale
p.281 "My Country" by Sarah Josepha Hale

- In Sarah Josepha Hale's poem "My Country" on page 281, each stanza ends in variations of the refrain "Where man is free" or "And all are free." This repetition emphasizes the foundational pride she felt in America. Perhaps this is not surprising since we know how hard she fought to make Thanksgiving a national holiday!



Term 2

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 87

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Louisa May Alcott makes another appearance in this week's poems. You may remember from her biography last term that the abolition of slavery and women's rights were important to Alcott, and you'll see those themes in today's poem.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.281 "The Wild Birds Sing in the Orange Groves"

p.277-281 Chapter: Slavery and Freedom

If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 88

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.277-281 Chapter: Slavery and Freedom

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 89

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.63 Reread "Lady Icicle" by Pauline Johnson.

- How does Johnson describe winter here? Does that differ from how we usually describe winter?

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Video Link: Musical Performance of "Lady Icicle"

→ ILLUSTRATE (OPTIONAL)

Illustrate the poem with a picture of winter and/or Little Lady Icicle as Johnson describes them.

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 90

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.15-16

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

Read this acrostic poem by Pauline Johnson.

∞ Link: "Canada" Poem

- In an acrostic poem, the first letter of each line forms a word. In this poem, they spell the name "CANADA."

→ WRITE (OPTIONAL)

If time allows, write your own acrostic poem using the letters in your first name.

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 91

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Christina Moody was a young African American poet who did something truly remarkable: she published her own book of poetry called *A Tiny Spark* when she was just sixteen years old! Her poems were bold and brave for their time, tackling big questions like what it really means to be Black in America and the complicated feelings of pledging allegiance to a country that didn't treat all of its people equally. The book is incredibly rare today, with only a handful of copies known to exist in the entire world. Not much is known about Christina's life beyond this one extraordinary book, but she was a courageous and talented young woman who deserves to be remembered.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.294 "A Tale Told By Grandma" by Christina Moody
p.296 "The Depth From Whence We Came" by Christina Moody
p.298 "The Negro's Flag and Country" by Christina Moody

- Note that Moody was between 13 and 16 years of age when she wrote these poems!

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Christina Moody Bio

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 92

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.284 "The Tree of Slavery" Author Unknown

- A poem that takes a shape like this one is called a calligram.

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Article Link: How to Create a Calligram

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 93

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Henry Wadsworth Longfellow makes another appearance this week with the poem "The Slave's Dream." Longfellow was a committed abolitionist who used his poetry and his money to support the anti-slavery cause. Longfellow published a collection of poems that detailed the cruelties of slavery and helped draw public attention to the cause. He also regularly contributed funds to purchase the freedom of enslaved people, support freedom seekers, and aid abolitionist organizations.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.292-293 "The Slave's Dream" by Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 94

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.530 "The Birds' Lullaby" by Pauline Johnson

- What lines are repeated in this poem? What rhythm or motion do those words give the poem?

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 95

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS p.17-18

- Pauline Johnson's home on the Six Nations Reserve was close to the Anglican mission where her father, George H.M. Johnson, worked. He was an interpreter and cultural negotiator between the Mohawk, the British, and the Government of Canada. Her family's Christian faith heavily influenced her poetry.

→ READ (OPTIONAL) ∞ Link: Christmastide Poem

WEEK 8 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 96

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Fenton Johnson was born in 1888 into one of Chicago's wealthiest African American families and attended top universities like the University of Chicago and Columbia. He wrote bold, free-verse poems about what life was really like for African Americans in the city, which was groundbreaking for his time. He even started his own literary magazines to help get new voices heard. He's considered one of the key figures who helped set the stage for the Harlem Renaissance, the incredible explosion of African American art, music, and literature that took off in the 1920s. He also wrote short stories, essays, and plays.

→ READ & DISCUSS p.306 "The Plaint of the Factory Child" by Fenton Johnson

- "The Plaint of the Factory Child" criticizes the exploitation of child labor during the Industrial Era. Read the poem again aloud and see if you can hear how the steady rhythm and repetition of the poem mimics the relentless machinery of the factories.

WEEK 8 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 97

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS p.301-306 Chapter: Politics and Social Reform Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week. (Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 8 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 98

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS p.301-306 Chapter: Politics and Social Reform Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week. (Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 8 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 99

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS p.530 "The Birds' Lullaby"

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

Reread this poem by Pauline Johnson. In a previous lesson, we discussed the repetition and rhythm of this poem. This time, as you read, move side to side slowly in rhythm with the poem.

- (Optional) Have one student (or group of students or teacher) read the end word of a line and another student (or group of students) read the end word of the next line that rhymes (creeping /sleeping, through /you, sighing /lying, reply /lullaby, lowly/slowly, strong/song).

WEEK 8 📅 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 100

📖 Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ **READ & DISCUSS**
p.19-20

→ **VIEW (OPTIONAL)**
The birthplace of Pauline Johnson is now a National Historic Site in Canada.
∞ Link: Birthplace of Pauline Johnson

WEEK 9 📅 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 101

📖 Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ **INTRO**
Robert Frost is one of the most famous poets in American history, but his road to success was anything but smooth. He dropped out of college twice, worked as a chicken farmer, and had barely been published until he was almost 40! Desperate for a fresh start, he packed up his whole family and sailed to England in 1912. British publishers loved his writing, and he came back to America a celebrity. He went on to win four Pulitzer Prizes and wrote some of the most-quoted lines in the English language.

→ **READ & DISCUSS**
p.321 "La Noche Triste"
Read Robert Frost's poem about Tenochtitlan. Written when he was just sixteen years old, it is the very first poem he ever composed and shows his early interest in history and human conflict.

• **EXTRA HELPING**
∞ **Article Link:** Robert Frost Bio

WEEK 9 📅 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 102

📖 Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ **READ & DISCUSS**
p.321 "The Sachem Of The Clouds" by Robert Frost

- This poem is written in quatrain (4 lines per stanza) with an AABB rhyme scheme.

WEEK 9 📅 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 103

📖 Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ **READ & DISCUSS**
p.325 "A Secret" by Lizzie M. Hadley

- What is the "terrible thing" that Belle and Sue's papas are afraid of? Is it something different than what they imagine? Is this poem still relatable today?

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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WEEK 9 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 104

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.530-531 "Lullaby of the Iroquois" by Pauline Johnson

- Lullabies are usually sung, not read. Read a few lines of this poem aloud and pay attention to how it feels. Does hearing it change how you understand it compared to reading it silently?

WEEK 9 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 105

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.21-23

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

West Wind Blow From Your Prairie Nest is an album dedicated to the indigenous culture of North America. Created at the Institute of American Indian Arts (IAIA), with the support of the CEC ArtsLink Fellowship, the album sets to music original poems written by renowned Native poets.
∞ Video Link: Musical Performance of "The Song My Paddle Sings" (Listen to all or part.)

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 106

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

You might not know Anna Bartlett Warner's name, but there's a good chance you know her most famous words. She wrote the hymn "Jesus Loves Me," one of the most recognized songs in the world. Born in New York in 1827, she was a prolific writer who published 31 novels on her own and several more with her sister Susan, often writing under the pen name Amy Lothrop. She lived most of her life on Constitution Island, right across from the West Point Military Academy, and her family home is now a museum that has been restored to look just as it did in her lifetime.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.330 "Jesus Loves Me" by Anna Bartlett Warner

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Video Link: Hymn Stories: Jesus Loves Me

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Anna Bartlett Warner Bio

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 107

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.329 "Nearer Home" by Phoebe Cary

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

This poem is also a hymn that uses the first line as the title.
∞ Video Link: One Sweetly Solemn Thought

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 108

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood, Bible

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.331 "Despondency" by Louisa May Alcott

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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Note that Alcott was about 12 years old when she wrote this poem.

- Read Matthew 6:26-30 (and its parallel, Luke 12:24-28).

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 109

Materials: Link

→ READ & DISCUSS

∞ Link: "The Homing Bee" by Pauline Johnson

- How many times does Johnson use the phrase "little brother"? At what point did you guess who the little brother was?
- (Optional) Based on the poems you've read so far by Pauline Johnson, what do you think she believed about the relationship between humans and nature?

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 110

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.24-27

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

This brief news story is about a play that reenacts what Pauline's performances might have looked like.

∞ Video Link: Paddle Song: One-Woman Play

WEEK 11 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 111

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Harriet McEwen Kimball was a poet and hymn writer from Portsmouth, New Hampshire. She was known in her day as "The Poetess of the Church." She was home educated by her mother, who was described as cultured and accomplished. She started writing poetry at a young age with her parents' encouragement and went on to publish several collections of deeply religious poetry and hymns that ended up in church songbooks all across the country. She was part of the same circle of poets as Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, was a personal friend of John Greenleaf Whittier, and was also a generous philanthropist.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.357 "The Fairy Taper" by Harriet McEwen Kimball

- Ironically, while Harriet McEwen Kimball was best known for her hymns and religious poems, the only poem featured in our book is her poem about fairies! You can read some of her hymns at the link below.

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Link: Harriet McEwen Kimball Hymns

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Harriet McEwen Kimball Bio

WEEK 11 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 112

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Emily Dickinson appears in this chapter again with the poem "The Sea of Sunset." While the version in our book omits Dickinson's trademark em dashes, you can see how they were originally included in the link below. Try reading both versions out loud to see if the dashes make a difference

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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in how the poem sounds.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.362 "The Sea of Sunset" by Emily Dickinson

→ VIEW

∞ Link: "The Sea of Sunset"

WEEK 11 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 113

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.355-362 Chapter: Fairy and Folk

Feel free to pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 11 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 114

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.28-30

→ WRITE

(Optional) Write and perform your own poem inspired by Pauline Johnson, just as Kathy did in the book. (You can work on this in the next lesson if you don't finish.)

WEEK 11 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 115

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

Use the author index in the back of the book to revisit your favorite poems by Pauline Johnson.

OR

Continue to work on your poem inspired by Pauline Johnson and perform it for someone.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 116

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

There are no exams for this course.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 117

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

There are no exams for this course.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 118

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

There are no exams for this course.

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WEEK 12 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 119 Exam Week → EXAMS There are no exams for this course.	
WEEK 12 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 120 Exam Week → EXAMS There are no exams for this course.	

Poetry: Grades 5-6

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WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 121

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

John Greenleaf Whittier grew up on a farm in Massachusetts in the early 1800s, where his love of reading sparked a passion for writing poetry. His sister secretly sent one of his poems to a newspaper, which kicked off his whole career. Whittier became one of the loudest voices against slavery in America, even when it was dangerous to do so. He helped found the American Anti-Slavery Society and signed the Anti-Slavery Declaration of 1833. After slavery was abolished, he wrote cozy, heartfelt poems about New England life and became one of the most beloved poets in the country.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.371-372 "Red Riding-Hood" by John Greenleaf Whittier

- How does this poem about Red-Riding Hood differ from the traditional fairy tale?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: John Greenleaf Whittier Bio

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 122

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.368-369

Read the three poems about mermaids on these pages. How are they similar or different?

- (Optional) Films like "The Little Mermaid" may make us think of mermaids as beautiful and harmless. However, mermaids have been depicted in many ways throughout history, and they were commonly seen as a sign of danger (such as an impending shipwreck). How are these mermaids depicted?

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 123

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.372-373 "Little Orphant Annie" by James Whitcomb Riley
(We will learn more about Riley later this term.)

- "Little Orphant Annie" was written in 1885. It was first titled "The Elf Child," and the name was changed by Riley to "Little Orphant Annie" at its third printing. ("Orphant" is an obsolete form of the word "orphan.") It served as the inspiration for the comic strip Little Orphan Annie, which then inspired a Broadway musical, several movies, and many radio and television programs.

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 124

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ INTRO

Paul Laurence Dunbar was one of the first Black Americans to earn a living as a writer, and he inspired many other literary giants who would come after him. In fact, "I know why the caged bird sings" (one of the most iconic lines in African American literature and the title of Maya Angelou's autobiography) comes from one of Dunbar's poems. He was the only Black student in his high school, and became friends with Orville Wright and his brother Wilbur (who you may remember as the inventors of the airplane).

★ TEACHER NOTE

Sensitive Content

Consideration: Some illustrations in the book should be previewed by the teacher.

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Paul Laurence Dunbar Bio

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The Wright brothers owned a printing press and published Dunbar's first writings. While Dunbar only lived to age 33, he has been described as "your favorite poet's favorite poet" due to the impact his large body of work had on future writers. Older students may want to read more about Dunbar in the Extra Helping.

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.1-4

- Why do you think the book says "it's almost like two different men wrote those two poems"? What are some of the differences?

WEEK 1 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 125

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.5-10

→ **VIEW**
∞ Image & Article Link: Fifth Massachusetts Colored Cavalry

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 126

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Clement Clarke Moore was born in 1779 in New York City and became a college professor of ancient languages. On Christmas Eve 1822, he reportedly wrote a fun poem just to entertain his kids. That poem, "Account Of A Visit from St. Nicholas," was the first to give Santa's reindeer their names and went on to become one of the most beloved Christmas poems ever. It was published anonymously in a New York newspaper in 1823, and Moore didn't claim authorship until 1844. However, the family of another writer, Henry Livingston Jr., argued that he was the real author! Computer analysis in the early 2000s even suggested the poem had more in common with Livingston's known writing style than Moore's. So, the mystery of who really wrote "'Twas the Night Before Christmas" may never be fully solved!

→ **READ & DISCUSS**
p.383-384 "Account Of A Visit From St. Nicholas" by Clement Clarke Moore

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 127

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

We learned about Henry Wadsworth Longfellow earlier this year, and today we will read his poem "Christmas Bells." This popular poem was set to music pretty early on and has been recorded many times over the years. Listen to the version below if time allows.

∞ (Optional) Video Link: I Heard the Bells

Longfellow wrote this poem in 1863 at one of the lowest points of his life. His wife had recently died in a tragic accident, and his son had just been wounded fighting in the Civil War. When he heard church bells ringing on Christmas morning, he was struck by the contrast between their message of peace and the suffering around him. That tension became his poem "Christmas Bells."

When the poem was set to music in 1872, the stanzas referencing the Civil

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ **Video Link:** Christmas Bells Movie

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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War were removed, and the title changed to "I Heard The Bells On Christmas Day." Today, millions of people sing the carol every holiday season.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.389 "Christmas Bells" by Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

Henry Wadsworth Longfellow wrote "Christmas Bells" while sitting by his son's bedside. Read more about the story behind this poem in the link below, as time allows.

∞ Article Link: The Story Behind "Christmas Bells"

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 128

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

We read about Eugene Field earlier this year and read his poem "The Duel" with an unreliable narrator who got his information from a Chinese plate and an old Dutch clock! Today, we'll read one of his poems about Christmas. As you read, think about who the author wants you to believe is narrating (or writing the poem).

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.391 "Jest 'Fore Christmas" by Eugene Field

- Who does the author want you to believe is writing the poem? What is his advice about getting ready for Christmas?
- Earlier this year, we read a poem written in vernacular to sound like the way the grandmother talked ("A Tale Told by Grandma" on page 294). Today's poem is written to sound like a young boy. Why do you think so many famous writers use this technique in their writing?

★ TEACHER NOTE

Writing in vernacular can show where a character is from, highlight a culture, and add authenticity and interest to a poem. Some people make a distinction between vernacular and dialect:

vernacular - using plain, everyday, ordinary language used by ordinary people, such as slang or local expressions.

dialect - language spoken in a particular geographical area or by members of a particular social class or occupational group, with unique vocabulary, grammar, and pronunciation

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 129

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.11-16

WEEK 2 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 130

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.17-21

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 131

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

James Russell Lowell was born in 1819 in Cambridge, Massachusetts. He graduated from Harvard but was banned from the graduation ceremonies for breaking the rules! During his suspension, he stayed with a reverend in Concord, where he met poets Ralph Waldo Emerson and Henry David Thoreau, though his relationship with Thoreau would later sour. He skipped a career in law to pursue writing instead. His wife, Maria, strongly opposed slavery and pushed him toward more active involvement in the abolitionist cause. The couple gave their own money to help people escaping enslavement, even when times were tough financially. In 1849, he contributed toward purchasing a slave's freedom,

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: James Russell Lowell Bio

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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writing, "if my poems were more popular my gifts should be larger." Lowell also joined the Boston Vigilance Committee, a group that provided shelter, clothing, money, and safe passage to slaves seeking freedom on the Underground Railroad. Lowell became the first editor of the Atlantic Monthly and even served as U.S. ambassador to Spain and Great Britain.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.408 "The Fatherland" by James Russell Lowell

- Fatherland means the country, nation, or land you came from. For example, Irish immigrants to America in the 1800s would call Ireland their fatherland.
- Look for repetition at the end of the stanzas in "The Fatherland." What do you think Lowell was trying to emphasize through this repetition?

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 132

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

In the last lesson, we read about poet James Russell Lowell. Later in life, Lowell succeeded his friend and fellow poet Henry Wadsworth Longfellow as Professor of Modern Languages at Harvard University. Today, we'll read one of Longfellow's most famous poems, titled "Paul Revere's Ride," about this famous event during the American Revolutionary War. Though "Paul Revere's Ride" is on the surface about a Revolutionary War event, it was written on the cusp of the Civil War. The poem was meant as a call to arms, rousing northerners to action as war loomed.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.410-413 "Paul Revere's Ride" by Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ PDF Link: "Paul Revere's Ride" Awakening Abolitionists

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 133

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.408-413 (top of page) Chapter: Histories
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 134

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.22-24

WEEK 3 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 135

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.26-28

- Why do you think Paul's education was so important to his mother, Matilda?

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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WEEK 4 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 136

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Oliver Wendell Holmes was born in Cambridge, Massachusetts. He became a professor of anatomy at Harvard Medical School and was eventually made its dean, a position he held until 1882. He was also one of the "Fireside Poets," beloved for writing poetry that families could enjoy together. His most famous poem, "Old Ironsides," helped save the historic warship USS Constitution from being scrapped by the Navy. His son was Oliver Wendell Holmes Jr., who became an Associate Justice of the Supreme Court of the United States. Holmes Jr. graduated from Harvard in 1861, right as the Civil War was breaking out, and enlisted in the Union Army. He was wounded three times, and his father wrote a famous essay about frantically searching for his son after the Battle of Antietam.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.413-417 "Grandmother's Story of Bunker-Hill Battle: As She Saw It From the Belfry" by Oliver Wendell Holmes
This poem was written for the centennial (100th) anniversary of this Revolutionary War battle. Watch for an interesting twist at the end of the poem regarding the legacy of an injured soldier.

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Oliver Wendell Holmes Bio

WEEK 4 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 137

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

We learned about Walt Whitman earlier in the year, and today we'll read one of his most famous poems, "O Captain! My Captain!"

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.422-423

- This poem is one of two memorial poems Whitman wrote about the assassination of President Abraham Lincoln. In the poem, Lincoln is the "captain," and the United States is the ship.

WEEK 4 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 138

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.422 "A Drummer" by Margaret Sangster

- Drummer boys in the American Civil War were vital for battlefield communication, using distinct drum cadences to relay commands like "charge" or "retreat" amid the chaos. Some of the boys were as young as nine years old!

→ VIEW

∞ Article Link: Civil War Drummer Boy

WEEK 4 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 139

□ Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.29-31

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: Black Soldiers in the Civil War

WEEK 4 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 140

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.32-36

- We read "Little Orphant Annie" in a previous lesson and will learn more about James Whitcomb Riley in an upcoming lesson!

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 141

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Charlotte Perkins Gilman was born in 1860 in Connecticut. She had a tough childhood and attended school sporadically at best. However, she loved reading in the library, and she especially loved "natural philosophy," which is what physics was called back then.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.437 "Little Cell" by Charlotte Perkins Gilman

→ WRITE

(Optional) Charlotte Perkins Gilman's love of science may have influenced her to write "Little Cell." Try your hand today at writing a poem about a topic or object that isn't commonly featured in poetry.

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Charlotte Perkins Gilman Bio

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 142

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.437-441 Chapter: Science and Technology
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

→ WRITE

(Optional) Continue writing or revising your poem today if needed.

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 143

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.437-441 Chapter: Science and Technology
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 144

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.37-40

Poetry: Grades 5-6

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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WEEK 5 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 145

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.41-44

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 146

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Lucy Larcom was born in 1824 in Beverly, Massachusetts, the ninth of ten children. She loved books from a very early age and read everything she could find. According to her autobiography, she wrote and self-published her own poetry collections at just seven years old! When her father died and her family needed money, she went to work in a cotton mill at age eleven, but she never stopped writing. She grew up to become a well-known poet, teacher, and author whose words are still remembered today.

→ **READ & DISCUSS**

p.454 "What the Train Ran Over" by Lucy Larcom

- "What the Train Ran Over" by Lucy Larcom is considered a ballad. A ballad is a poem that tells a story and sometimes is set to music. Ballads are usually organized in quatrains of four lines with a catchy rhythm and lots of repetition.
- What other ballads have you read this year that told a story?

• **EXTRA HELPING**

∞ **Article Link:** Lucy Larcom Bio

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 147

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ **READ & DISCUSS**

p.450-454 Chapter: Science and Technology
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 148

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ **READ & DISCUSS**

p.450-454 Chapter: Science and Technology
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 149

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.45-47 (stop after poem)

→ **VIEW (OPTIONAL)**

∞ **Article Link:** Frederick Douglass

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WEEK 6 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 150

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.47-48 (start at "How do you suppose")

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 151

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ **READ & DISCUSS**
Read the description of samplers before the poem, and then read the poem.
p.470 "Sarah Orne's Sampler" by Sarah Loring Bailey

→ **VIEW (OPTIONAL)**
Explore these photos of samplers. Girls usually completed sewing their first sampler around age 8 or 9.
∞ Link: Photos of Samplers

→ **WRITE (OPTIONAL)**
What would you embroider on a sampler? Choose a Bible verse or short poem, or write an original verse.

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 152

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ **READ & DISCUSS**
p.461-470 Chapter: Homework and Handwork
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 153

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ **READ & DISCUSS**
p.461-470 Chapter: Homework and Handwork
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 154

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.50-53

- Why do you think this poem is called a sermon? What is the message of the sermon?

WEEK 7 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 155

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.54-56

- What does the author mean when he says, "Studying a poem isn't like solving a problem in math"?



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WEEK 8 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 156

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

William Oland Bourne was a writer, minister, and helper of others who lived during the time of the Civil War. When soldiers were wounded in battle and lost their arms, he created a special newsletter called The Soldier's Friend to support them. Bourne even organized left-handed handwriting contests for veterans who had lost their right arms. Because of his work standing up for people with disabilities, he is considered a pioneer in disability rights. He also wrote poetry, books of fables, and stories for children.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.475 "The Busy Knitter" by William Oland Bourne
"The Busy Knitter" uses repetition at the end of each stanza. As you read the poem out loud, listen for the recurring refrain, "She was sitting, Knitting, knitting," which mimics the rhythmic click-clack of knitting needles.

WEEK 8 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 157

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.477 "A Song From the Suds" by Louisa May Alcott

- Why do you think Alcott chose to call this a "song"?
- Alcott wrote this poem during a time when most women (especially working-class women) had very few choices about how they spent their lives. Can a person find real joy in work they did not necessarily choose?
- (Optional) If time allows, use the author index in the back of the book to explore other poems by Louisa May Alcott.

WEEK 8 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 158

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.475-480 Chapter: Homework and Handwork
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 8 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 159

□ Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.57-60 (stop after poem)

WEEK 8 □ 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 160

□ Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.60-66 (Start at "It was time")

Poetry: Grades 5-6

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WEEK 9 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 161

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Paul Laurence Dunbar was the first poet we read about this year! You may remember that he was one of the first Black Americans to earn a living as a writer, and he inspired many other writers after him.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.486 "Little Brown Baby" by Paul Laurence Dunbar

→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: Reading of "Little Brown Baby"

- Use any extra time to explore the author index on page 559 and revisit some of Dunbar's poems!

WEEK 9 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 162

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.485-487 Chapter: Family Ties
Pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 9 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 163

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.485-487 Chapter: Family Ties
Pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 9 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 164

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.67-71

WEEK 9 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 165

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.73-78

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 166

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

James Whitcomb Riley was a poet from Greenfield, Indiana, who loved making up rhymes even as a little kid. His very first poems were valentines he made for his friends! He skipped out on school as much as he could, preferring to wander outside and read on his own. He worked all kinds of odd jobs before becoming famous as a writer. He wrote about everyday people and the Indiana countryside in the way people actually talked, earning the nicknames "the Hoosier Poet" and "the Children's Poet." His best-known poems include "Little Orphant Annie" (which we

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read earlier) and "The Raggedy Man."

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.497 "The Raggedy Man" by James Whitcomb Riley

- Who is the Raggedy Man? What do we learn about him, and what does the poet leave unsaid?
- (Optional) Read a stanza slowly and then read it again faster. Which seems like a better fit?

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 167

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.493 "The Children's Hour" by Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

- What is the rhyme structure of this poem? (Which lines rhyme and which do not?)
- This poem uses metaphor (a comparison of two things that are generally unlike) to compare the daughters' invasion of his study to a military siege. What words does Longfellow use that sound like a siege?

★ TEACHER NOTE

The rhyme structure is ABCB. This is a common ballad form, and it gives the poem a song-like, storytelling quality.

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 168

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.494 "To Mother" by Louisa May Alcott

- This poem is addressed to Louisa's mother, Abigail May Alcott. Abigail was the real-life inspiration for the beloved mother ("Marmee") in Alcott's novel, Little Women.

p.495-496 "The Lay Of A Golden Goose" by Louisa May Alcott

- The word lay in the title is a pun. A lay is an old word for a song or poem, but geese also lay eggs.
- (Optional) If Louisa May Alcott herself is the goose, what is she trying to say about her life?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Abigail May Alcott Bio

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 169

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.79-84

WEEK 10 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 170

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.85-90

WEEK 11 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 171

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ INTRO

Mary Mapes Dodge was an influential 19th-century American author and editor, best remembered for her novel Hans Brinker, or The Silver Skates. As the foundational editor of St. Nicholas Magazine, she played a massive

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Mary Mapes Dodge Bio

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role in shaping American children's literature, writing with a deep understanding of childhood imagination and innocence.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.525 "The Sand Man" by Mary Mapes Dodge

WEEK 11 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 172

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.525 "The Sand-Man" by Paul Laurence Dunbar

- How is this poem about the sandman similar or different to the one we read yesterday (featured just below it on the page)?

WEEK 11 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 173

Materials: Over the River and Through the Wood

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.526 "Lullaby" by Louisa May Alcott

- Lullabies are one of the oldest forms of poetry (usually sung) and are found in every culture. What qualities do you think make a good lullaby?
- As time allows, revisit some of Alcott's other poems by checking the author index on page 559.

WEEK 11 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 174

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.91-93

WEEK 11 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 175

Materials: Jump Back, Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.95-100

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Video Link: Paul Laurence Dunbar Home

WEEK 12 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 176

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

There are no exams for this course.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 177

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

There are no exams for this course.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 178

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

There are no exams for this course.

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WEEK 12 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 179 Exam Week → EXAMS There are no exams for this course.	
WEEK 12 5m Poetry: Grades 5-6 - Lesson 180 Exam Week → EXAMS There are no exams for this course.	